Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475 · Paper 1 Prose

I’m the King of the Castle

Susan Hill · A revision guide

For examination in 2028

Event bank · Quote bank · Theme arcs by chapter and across the novel

Essay practice · Self-test

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How to use this guide

Every event, claim and quotation in this guide is tied to the novel. References take the form 7 (40%): Chapter 7, about 40 per cent of the way through the chapter. Positions are rounded to the nearest 5 per cent. This works in any edition: find the chapter, then estimate how far into it you need to go. Ranges look like 12 (35–100%).

> **Two ways to read the banks.** The event bank and quote bank run in chapter order, so you can revise one chapter at a time or read straight through for the arc of the whole novel. The theme arcs group the seventeen chapters into four movements: arrival and first torments (1–4), Hang Wood and its aftermath (5–10), the shed, the castle and Fielding (11–14), and the closing of the trap (15–17).

The examination

Syllabus	Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475, syllabus for 2028, 2029 and 2030. The novel is a Paper 1 Section B (Prose) set text for 2028 only (p. 13). It is also on the 2027 list (2027 syllabus, p. 12).
Paper	Paper 1 Poetry and Prose (Open text): 1 hour 30 minutes, 50 marks, 50% of the qualification, compulsory for all candidates. One question from Section A (Poetry) and one from Section B (Prose), each worth 25 marks (pp. 9, 21).
Questions on this novel	A choice of two essay questions. There is no passage-based question on prose texts from 2028 (pp. 9, 36).
Open text	From 2028 Paper 1 is an open-text paper, so you may take your copy into the exam (p. 36). Highlighting, underlining and brief notes of words and phrases are allowed; sticky notes, inserted paper and extended notes are not (pp. 20, 23).
Assessment objectives	AO1 knowledge of the text with reference; AO2 understanding of meanings, contexts, ideas and attitudes; AO3 how the writer uses language, structure and form; AO4 an informed personal response. All four are tested in every question (pp. 10, 21).

What this means for revision. Because there is no printed passage on the 2028 paper, you need to be able to find three or four moments quickly in your own copy and build an argument across them. The event bank, quote bank and issue arcs are organised for that. The Past questions section maps the twenty questions set on this novel in earlier Cambridge papers (0486, 2014–2016) to the text: use their extract questions for close-reading practice and their essay questions as practice for the current paper.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

Where the novel began

Hill writes that in the summer of 1969 she rented a cottage on a farm in a remote part of Dorset, beside an ancient wood actually called Hang Wood, with deer coming down to a stream.

Source: Susan Hill, Afterword

The two boys

She describes watching the farmer's grandson and his friend, two prep-school boys who seemed the best of friends, and says her two characters grew out of them, although they were nothing like Kingshaw and Hooper. By the end of the holiday the book was begun and outlined.

Source: Susan Hill, Afterword

A book about children, written for adults

Hill says the novel is mainly about children but was written as an adult for adults, and names Dickens, Katherine Mansfield and Elizabeth Bowen as writers who did the same. She also reports that it has long been a GCE and GCSE set book and that young readers often find it truer than their parents do.

Source: Susan Hill, Afterword

Hill on the ending

Asked whether a child would really take his own life, Hill answers that children have and do, and that she still sees the ending as inevitable for Kingshaw.

Source: Susan Hill, Afterword

Hill on what the novel is about

She calls it a novel about cruelty and the power of evil, but most of all about isolation and the lack of love: no one in it is loved, and the adults are made selfish and blind by that lack. She singles out Fielding as the one boy who has known ordinary love, and says he has no power to save the others.

Source: Susan Hill, Afterword

Susan Hill

Hill was born in Scarborough and published her first novel while still a student, the year she began at King's College London. From the late 1960s she wrote a run of acclaimed novels, of which this, published in 1970, was one; her most popular books are ghost stories and crime fiction, and The Woman in Black (1983) became a stage play that has run in the West End for more than twenty years. LitCharts dates the writing to 1969, in line with Hill's own account of the summer of 1969, though it names Stratford-upon-Avon and London rather than Dorset as places of writing.

Source: LitCharts, Brief Biography and Key Facts p. 1; Susan Hill, Afterword

The Gothic tradition

LitCharts places the novel in the tradition of Gothic fiction: an atmosphere of fear and gloom, an isolated old house that seems to have a will of its own, and a forbidden room. It notes that Jane Eyre also has a red-room, so Hill's Red Room reads as a deliberate echo. Warings itself is old, gloomy and cut off 1 (30%).

Source: LitCharts, Introduction and Symbols (Warings, the Red Room)

Children capable of evil

LitCharts compares the novel with William Golding's Lord of the Flies (1954): both are told through children but are not children's books, and both show children as psychologically complex and capable of cruelty. Hill makes a similar point in the Afterword when she says the book was written for adults.

Source: LitCharts, Introduction; Susan Hill, Afterword

Property and class

LitCharts reads the boys' conflict through English property and class. The text supports the starting point: the Hooper estate has been sold off, piece by piece, leaving only the house 1 (30%), and Hooper values it for what owning it means rather than for itself 1 (35%). The wider history LitCharts gives (enclosure and the rise of landed estates) is background, not something the novel mentions.

Source: LitCharts, Historical Context and Themes

Using the Afterword in an answer

The Afterword is the author's later reflection, not part of the novel. Quote it sparingly and treat it as one view: Cambridge rewards your reading of the text (AO4), and Hill herself says she does not fully understand the book.

Source: Susan Hill, Afterword; 0475 syllabus, assessment objectives (p. 10)

Context inside the text

Prep school	Kingshaw boards at St Vincent's, and the memories of school (Devereux, Crawford, Fenwick) show a world of other boys he half belongs to 15 (25%).
Money and dependence	Kingshaw's mother is a housekeeper; Hooper reminds him that Mr Hooper is paying for the uniform 15 (45%).
The country house	Warings is old family property with its history and collections 1 (35%).
Derne	The village below Warings, which the narrator compares to a port deserted by the sea 1 (30%).

At a glance

Chapter	Setting	Events	Event titles
Chapter 1	Warings; the Red Room	E1–E2	The dying grandfather; Warings, the Red Room and the father
Chapter 2	Warings: arrival	E3–E4	The note; First questions, first fight, the tour
Chapter 3	Cornfield; Red Room	E5–E7	The crow in the cornfield; The stuffed crow on the bed; Locked in the Red Room
Chapter 4	The small room; train to London	E8–E9	The room with the dolls; The train to London; the adults misread the boys
Chapter 5	Running away at dawn	E10–E11	Running away; Into Hang Wood
Chapter 6	Hang Wood	E12–E12	Hooper has followed
Chapter 7	Hang Wood: storm and stream	E13–E15	The storm; The dead rabbit; lost; The stream: Hooper hurt
Chapter 8	Hang Wood: night	E16–E16	Night in the wood
Chapter 9	Hang Wood: found	E17–E17	Found
Chapter 10	Warings	E18–E19	Hooper's lie; The little talk
Chapter 11	A shed in the fields	E20–E21	The new school; Locked in the shed
Chapter 12	Leydell Castle	E22–E23	Leydell Castle; The fall
Chapter 13	Warings; the car	E24–E26	Ignored; King of the Castle at night; the drive home; The nightmare
Chapter 14	Warings; hospital; Fielding's farm	E27–E29	Mrs Kingshaw at the hospital; The church; Fielding
Chapter 15	Warings; London	E30–E32	Hooper returns; The uniform; The model, the blow and his mother's verdict
Chapter 16	Warings; circus; Red Room	E33–E35	The wedding news; the circus; Fielding at Warings; The battle chart burned
Chapter 17	Warings; Hang Wood	E36–E38	The last note; Hang Wood: the drowning; Hooper finds him

Event bank

38 numbered events in order. Read one chapter for close revision, or E1 to E38 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Chapter 1

E1 The dying grandfather 1 (0–5%)

Edmund Hooper is taken to see his grandfather, who is dying upstairs after a second stroke 1 (0%). Joseph Hooper had hoped the meeting would be moving; it is not 1 (5%). Edmund's only comment compares the old man to one of his dead moths 1 (10%).

Why it matters. The novel opens on death treated without feeling, and introduces the moths before the Red Room is shown.

E2 Warings, the Red Room and the father 1 (10–90%)

Joseph Hooper, now master of the house, plans to find his son a companion 1 (15%). He keeps the key of the Red Room, where his father's cases of moths and butterflies are displayed 1 (70%). Edmund takes the key at night and goes in alone 1 (65%).

Why it matters. The house and its collection belong to the Hoopers; the moths become Hooper's first weapon.

Chapter 2

E3 The note 2 (0–25%)

Mrs Helena Kingshaw and Charles arrive. Hooper wraps a message round a lump of plasticine and drops it from his window 2 (20%). Kingshaw reads it in the hall: Hooper did not want him to come 2 (25%).

Why it matters. Hostility is declared before the boys have met. Hill gives it no cause.

E4 First questions, first fight, the tour 2 (25–100%)

Hooper interrogates Kingshaw about his flat and his dead father 2 (30%). When Kingshaw claims the bedroom window as his own, they fight 2 (45%) 2 (45%). Ordered to show him round, Hooper runs through the house listing rooms, and on the back stairs Kingshaw has the thought of pulling him over, and does not act on it 2 (100%).

Why it matters. Ownership is the ground of the conflict from the start: whose house, whose room.

Chapter 3

E5 The crow in the cornfield 3 (0–25%)

Walking alone towards Hang Wood, Kingshaw is attacked by a crow in the cornfield 3 (25%). Lying winded, he sees a figure at a top window 3 (20%); when the crow has gone, the narrator names the watcher: Hooper, at his bedroom window 3 (25%).

Why it matters. Chance supplies the fear, and Hooper has watched all of it.

E6 The stuffed crow on the bed 3 (50–60%)

That night Kingshaw finds a stuffed crow on his bed 3 (55%). He does not scream 3 (55%).

Why it matters. The second crow shows that the first was watched. Kingshaw's silence becomes his habit.

E7 Locked in the Red Room 3 (65–90%)

Hooper takes Kingshaw into the Red Room among the moth cases 3 (70%) and locks him in. Kingshaw will not shout 3 (85%) and is sick. Next morning Hooper denies knowing he was there 3 (90%).

Why it matters. The method is set: Hooper uses what Kingshaw fears and leaves no evidence.

Chapter 4

E8 The room with the dolls 4 (0–10%)

Kingshaw finds an unused room with a cabinet of old dolls, works on his galleon model there and locks the door 4 (5%).

Why it matters. His first defence copies Hooper's: withdrawal behind a locked door.

E9 The train to London; the adults misread the boys 4 (20–100%)

On the train, Hooper reads a horror comic while his father reflects on him 4 (20%). Hooper finds the hidden room and the things Kingshaw has been gathering, guesses his plan to run away, and announces that he will go too 4 (85%). The adults congratulate themselves on how well the boys get on 4 (100%).

Why it matters. Hill sets what the boys know against what the adults believe, in the same chapter.

Chapter 5

E10 Running away 5 (0–70%)

With the adults away in London for the day 5 (0%), Kingshaw sets his alarm for five and leaves at dawn with his savings and supplies 5 (10%). He is frightened, not adventurous 5 (30%).

Why it matters. Escape is planned with care and carried out in fear: Hill refuses the boys' adventure story.

E11 Into Hang Wood 5 (70–95%)

Kingshaw reaches the edge of the wood 5 (70%) and goes in.

Why it matters. The wood is unowned ground, outside Warings.

Chapter 6

E12 Hooper has followed 6 (0–95%)

Inside the wood Kingshaw discovers that Hooper has followed him 6 (25%). They track a deer, and when the way is lost Kingshaw hears fear in Hooper's voice for the first time 6 (95%).

Why it matters. The escape fails because it was watched, but the wood gives Kingshaw a competence he has nowhere else.

Chapter 7

E13 The storm 7 (0–15%)

A storm breaks; Hooper is terrified 7 (10%) while Kingshaw stays calm 7 (10%). Afterwards Kingshaw believes the storm has changed things between them 7 (15%), and the narrator adds that he has forgotten what Hooper is like.

Why it matters. The first reversal of power, and Hill marks its limits at once.

E14 The dead rabbit; lost 7 (20–65%)

Hooper taunts Kingshaw over a dead rabbit 7 (20%). When Hooper panics at being lost he beats the ground and screams 7 (65%), and Kingshaw slaps him across the face to stop him 7 (65%).

Why it matters. Each boy is shown in his own fear; neither is simply strong.

E15 The stream: Hooper hurt 7 (80–95%)

Exploring alone with a ball of string, Kingshaw thinks of walking away and leaving Hooper 7 (80%), but feels responsible for him 7 (85%) and goes back. He finds Hooper face down in the stream, bleeding from the head 7 (85%), hauls him out and lights the fire 7 (95%).

Why it matters. Kingshaw behaves well when he could leave; the novel will not reward it.

Chapter 8

E16 Night in the wood 8 (0–100%)

Kingshaw calls Hooper a bully for his cruelty to a fish 8 (15%), and then finds himself taunting Hooper in turn 8 (85%). Hooper has a nightmare and cries for his mother 8 (55%), and makes Kingshaw promise not to leave him. Kingshaw feels something has changed 8 (100%).

Why it matters. The fullest view of Hooper as a frightened child, and a hold that will not last the morning.

Chapter 9

E17 Found 9 (0–85%)

The searchers come the next morning 9 (0%). Kingshaw, lying in the stream, does not want to be found 9 (85%).

Why it matters. The water and the wood are where he is at peace, which prepares the ending.

Chapter 10

E18 Hooper's lie 10 (0–25%)

Hooper tells the adults that Kingshaw pushed him into the water 10 (0%). The adults believe Hooper, and Kingshaw's furious reply is heard as spite 10 (25%).

Why it matters. The decency of the wood is erased in a sentence. Truth carries no weight with the adults.

E19 The little talk 10 (65–100%)

Kingshaw realises his mother will marry Mr Hooper 10 (65%). When he says he hates Hooper, she calls it wicked talk 10 (90%). She tries to have a talk with him 10 (70%) and offers to sort out any small problem 10 (85%). Alone, he decides that only the wood is left to him 10 (100%).

Why it matters. The gap between what adults offer and what the boy needs is complete; the ending is now in view.

Chapter 11

E20 The new school 11 (0–35%)

At breakfast Kingshaw learns he will go to Hooper's school 11 (15%).

Why it matters. The last exit, a return to his old school, is closed.

E21 Locked in the shed 11 (10–95%)

Kingshaw hides in a shed in the fields and is locked in 11 (15%). Through the walls Hooper's whisper tells him what will happen at the new school 11 (75%). At lunchtime Hooper unlocks the door and runs off 11 (95%).

Why it matters. Hooper's threats move from the house to the future: the school becomes a second Warings.

Chapter 12

E22 Leydell Castle 12 (0–35%)

On a family outing to a ruined castle 12 (0%), Kingshaw climbs the walls and shouts the title rhyme 12 (35%).

Why it matters. The title becomes literal, and Kingshaw, not Hooper, says it.

E23 The fall 12 (65–100%)

Hooper has climbed after him and freezes with fear 12 (75%). Kingshaw talks him down, knows he could make him fall and knows he will not 12 (95%). When Kingshaw reaches out, Hooper flinches, steps back and falls 12 (100%).

Why it matters. Kingshaw's one act of mercy looks, from below, like the act he refused to commit.

Chapter 13

E24 Ignored 13 (0–10%)

Afterwards Kingshaw remembers being ignored 13 (0%). He knows that from a distance the fall would have looked like a push 13 (10%).

Why it matters. Kingshaw is invisible to the adults even at the centre of events.

E25 King of the Castle at night; the drive home 13 (50–75%)

Left with Mrs Boland, Kingshaw imagines Warings without Hooper 13 (70%). Driving home at midnight, Mr Hooper tells Mrs Kingshaw there is to be no blame 13 (75%).

Why it matters. Hill cuts from the boy's hope to the adults' comfort without comment.

E26 The nightmare 13 (80–100%)

Kingshaw wakes from a nightmare believing Hooper dead 13 (95%). The adults soothe him 13 (95%); Mr Hooper carries him back to bed, and he is comforted and ashamed 13 (100%).

Why it matters. The only physical comfort he receives comes from Hooper's father.

Chapter 14

E27 Mrs Kingshaw at the hospital 14 (0–35%)

His mother visits Hooper daily and asks Kingshaw for a message and a present 14 (20%).

Why it matters. The mother's attention moves to the other boy.

E28 The church 14 (35–45%)

Alone while Hooper is in hospital, Kingshaw goes into the empty village church 14 (35%) and prays that nothing will happen 14 (40%), admitting he fears Hooper more than anything in the world 14 (40%).

Why it matters. Even prayer turns back to Hooper. The scene ends with the arrival of Fielding.

E29 Fielding 14 (45–90%)

Kingshaw meets Fielding, a farmer's son, who shows him a calf being born 14 (60%). Fielding is easy and unafraid 14 (85%). On the farm Kingshaw watches birds being killed and holds Fielding's hamster 14 (70%) 14 (75%). Told about Hooper, Fielding cannot see the danger 14 (80%).

Why it matters. Ordinary goodness appears, and has no power to help.

Chapter 15

E30 Hooper returns 15 (0–65%)

Hooper comes home and knows everything 15 (0%). Mrs Kingshaw has become sharper with Charles 15 (35%). Hooper has learned about Fielding through her 15 (65%).

Why it matters. Even the new friendship is passed to Hooper by the adults.

E31 The uniform 15 (40–85%)

Kingshaw goes to London with Mr Hooper to buy the uniform of the new school 15 (40%). In the mirror, dressed like Hooper, he sees there is no hope 15 (85%).

Why it matters. The uniform makes the future visible and identical to Hooper.

E32 The model, the blow and his mother's verdict 15 (85–100%)

Kingshaw finds Hooper playing with the helter-skelter fort he made, which the adults have given away 15 (90%). When he protests, Mr Hooper strikes him across the cheek 15 (90%). Hooper smashes the model, and his mother, arriving at the door, tells Kingshaw he should be ashamed 15 (100%).

Why it matters. The adults' blindness becomes open injustice: the one adult act of violence in the novel falls on the wrong boy.

Chapter 16

E33 The wedding news; the circus 16 (0–55%)

On the telephone Mrs Kingshaw hints at her plans 16 (5%). Hooper tells Kingshaw that the adults are to marry and that he will have to obey 16 (40%). At the circus Kingshaw is sick 16 (55%).

Why it matters. The marriage closes the household around him; even Hooper minds, but cannot stop it.

E34 Fielding at Warings 16 (60–95%)

Mrs Kingshaw arranges for Fielding to visit 16 (60%). At Warings Hooper draws Fielding away towards the Red Room and the attics, and Kingshaw sends Fielding home 16 (90%).

Why it matters. Kingshaw gives up his one friend rather than watch Hooper take him.

E35 The battle chart burned 16 (95–100%)

Kingshaw takes Hooper's battle chart and lists of regiments and burns them by the copse 16 (95%); he expects to feel exultant and does not 16 (100%).

Why it matters. His one act of revenge gives him nothing.

Chapter 17

E36 The last note 17 (0–50%)

The night before school, a note is pushed under his door 17 (45%).

Why it matters. The second note answers the first: the novel's arc runs between them.

E37 Hang Wood: the drowning 17 (55–90%)

In the morning Kingshaw walks to Hang Wood, takes off his clothes by the stream 17 (85%) and lies face down in the deepest water 17 (90%).

Why it matters. He chooses the place where he was safe and competent.

E38 Hooper finds him 17 (90–100%)

Hooper leads the search to the wood 17 (90%). Seeing the body, he feels triumph 17 (95%), and Mrs Kingshaw comforts him 17 (95%).

Why it matters. The novel ends on the survivor and the adult who still cannot see.

Characters

Charles Kingshaw

Almost eleven 2 (5%); his father is dead and his mother has come to Warings as Mr Hooper's housekeeper 2 (0%).

- Reserved and used to defeat: he expects to lose 4 (70%).
- Afraid of water since a boy called Turville dared him into a swimming pool 3 (35%), yet happy swimming in the stream 7 (45%).
- Silent under attack: he does not scream at the crow or shout in the Red Room 3 (55%).
- Competent and responsible in the wood 7 (80%) 7 (85%).
- Morally firm on the castle wall 12 (95%), but disbelieved by every adult 13 (0%).

Arc. From a wary arrival to brief confidence in Hang Wood, then to hopelessness and death.

Edmund Hooper

Joseph Hooper's son and heir to Warings; his mother is dead 2 (80%).

- Hostile from the first day 2 (25%).
- Watchful and patient: his attacks use what he has seen 6 (25%).
- Frightened of storms, the dark and heights 8 (55%) 12 (75%).
- A fluent liar to adults 10 (0%), and triumphant at the end 17 (95%).

Arc. His power falters only in the wood and on the wall; by the end it is greater than before.

Joseph Hooper

Edmund's father, owner of Warings, a widower.

- Concerned with family line and appearances 1 (5%).
- Uses stock phrases instead of attention 4 (20%).
- Absolves everyone after the fall 13 (75%), yet is the one adult who physically comforts Kingshaw 13 (100%).

Arc. His courtship of Mrs Kingshaw advances as the boys' situation worsens.

Mrs Helena Kingshaw

Charles's widowed mother, housekeeper at Warings.

- Sees the move as her chance 2 (90%).
- Speaks in endearments and stock phrases 16 (60%) 10 (85%).
- Turns towards Mr Hooper and away from her son 15 (35%).

Arc. From anxious newcomer to fiancée; she ends comforting Hooper beside her son's body.

Fielding

A farmer's son Kingshaw meets while Hooper is in hospital.

- Easy, unafraid and practical 14 (60%).
- Cannot understand the danger 14 (80%).
- Sent away by Kingshaw when Hooper draws him in 16 (90%).

Arc. Hill's Afterword calls him the one character who has known love, and says he has no power to save the others (Afterword).

Themes

Each theme is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Cruelty and the power of the bully

Hooper's cruelty has no stated cause. Hill declares it before the boys meet 2 (25%) and ends without remorse 17 (95%). In her Afterword Hill calls Hooper evil and says she is unsure where that came from (Afterword).

Chapters 1–4	Hooper attacks through what he observes: the moths, the crow, the Red Room 3 (55%) 3 (70%). He leaves no evidence and denies everything 3 (90%). Quotations: Q1, Q4, Q5, Q6, Q7, Q8, Q9, Q11, Q14
Chapters 5–10	He follows Kingshaw into the wood 6 (25%), collapses in the storm, and then, safe again, lies to the adults 10 (0%). Quotations: Q17, Q24, Q27
Chapters 11–14	His threats move into the future, through the shed wall 11 (75%). After the fall he blames Kingshaw 15 (15%). Quotations: Q32, Q35, Q36
Chapters 15–17	The marriage gives him a new claim 16 (40%), and the last note completes the pattern 17 (45%). Quotations: Q44, Q48, Q52, Q55

The whole arc. The cruelty is constant; only its methods change, from objects in the house to words about the future.

Fear and the imagination

Fear runs through the novel, but its source changes. At first nature supplies it by chance; Hooper then reproduces it on purpose. Hooper has fears of his own, and the wood shows them.

Chapters 1–4	The crow attack is chance 3 (25%); the stuffed crow is design 3 (55%). Kingshaw meets both in silence 3 (55%). Quotations: Q3, Q7, Q9, Q10
Chapters 5–10	In Hang Wood, physical danger frightens him less than people do 7 (80%). Hooper is the one terrified by the storm and the dark 8 (55%). Quotations: Q15, Q17, Q31
Chapters 11–14	Locked in the shed, Kingshaw's imagination does Hooper's work for him 11 (85%). On the castle wall the fear is Hooper's 12 (75%). Quotations: Q41
Chapters 15–17	At the circus and in the house the fear is constant 16 (55%), and the last note brings it back 17 (50%). Quotations: Q45, Q52

The whole arc. Fear moves from the world into Kingshaw's mind, until the threat no longer needs Hooper to be present.

Adults who do not see

The adults are not cruel. They are occupied with each other, speak in ready-made phrases and believe what is convenient. The narrator states their ignorance outright 4 (100%).

Chapters 1–4	Mr Hooper hopes for a friend for his son 1 (15%) and offers stock phrases instead of attention 4 (20%). Quotations: Q2, Q11, Q12, Q13
Chapters 5–10	They believe Hooper's lie 10 (0%), and Mrs Kingshaw reduces her son's trouble before she hears it 10 (85%). Quotations: Q27, Q28, Q29, Q30
Chapters 11–14	After the fall Kingshaw is ignored 13 (0%); the adults agree there is no blame 13 (75%). Fielding, the one child with a loving home, cannot see the danger either 14 (80%). Quotations: Q37, Q38, Q39, Q40, Q43
Chapters 15–17	Mrs Kingshaw grows impatient with her son 15 (35%), passes his secrets to Hooper 15 (65%), and comforts the wrong boy at the end 17 (95%). Quotations: Q44, Q46, Q47, Q56

The whole arc. At every turn the adults could know, and their phrases keep them from knowing.

Power and its reversals

Power passes between the boys several times, and Hill makes each reversal temporary. Kingshaw himself sees the pattern on the castle wall 12 (90%).

Chapters 1–4	In the house Hooper has power because the house is his 2 (45%). Quotations: Q8
Chapters 5–10	In the wood Kingshaw leads 6 (95%), is calm in the storm 7 (10%) and cares for Hooper 7 (85%). The change is real but limited 8 (100%), and Hooper's lie ends it 10 (0%). Quotations: Q18, Q20, Q21, Q23, Q25
Chapters 11–14	On the castle wall Kingshaw could kill Hooper and chooses not to 12 (95%); the fall makes his mercy look like an attack 13 (10%). Quotations: Q32, Q33, Q34, Q35
Chapters 15–17	The marriage hands lasting power to Hooper 16 (40%). Kingshaw's revenge on the battle chart brings him nothing 16 (100%). Quotations: Q48, Q49, Q50, Q51

The whole arc. Each reversal is allowed and then withdrawn, so that by the end Kingshaw has no reason to expect another.

Isolation and the lack of love

Hill's Afterword names isolation and the lack of love as what the novel is most about, with Fielding as the one character who has known love (Afterword). Kingshaw is alone in a house that is not his, with a mother turned towards someone else.

Chapters 1–4	Kingshaw arrives into one more borrowed home 2 (20%) and makes a room of his own behind a locked door 4 (5%). Quotations: Q10
Chapters 5–10	He runs away with his savings 5 (10%) and would rather not be found 9 (85%). Back at Warings he sees his mother turning to Mr Hooper 10 (65%). Quotations: Q16, Q26, Q29
Chapters 11–14	He is ignored after the fall 13 (0%); the one embrace he receives comes from Mr Hooper 13 (100%). Fielding's ease makes him envious 14 (85%). Quotations: Q37, Q40, Q41, Q42, Q43
Chapters 15–17	He sends Fielding away 16 (90%) and sees no hope left 15 (85%). Quotations: Q45, Q46, Q49

The whole arc. Kingshaw loses each possible ally in turn: his mother, the wood's truce, Fielding, and finally the hope of another school.

The natural world and escape

The natural world first threatens Kingshaw and then becomes his only refuge. Hang Wood is where he is competent, and where he dies.

Chapters 1–4	The cornfield crow makes the open country frightening 3 (25%). Quotations: –
Chapters 5–10	In Hang Wood he is calm and capable 7 (80%), and in the stream he wants to stay 9 (85%). At home he decides the wood is all he has 10 (100%) Quotations: Q15, Q18, Q19, Q20, Q22, Q23, Q26, Q31
Chapters 11–14	Fielding's farm shows birth and ordinary life 14 (60%). Quotations: –
Chapters 15–17	He returns to the stream in Hang Wood to die 17 (90%). Quotations: Q53, Q54

The whole arc. The same water that comforted him in Chapter 9 is where he drowns in Chapter 17.

Theme and chapter grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that theme's arc.

Theme	Chapters 1–4	Chapters 5–10	Chapters 11–14	Chapters 15–17
Cruelty and the power of the bully	Q1, Q4, Q5, Q6, Q7, Q8, Q9, Q11, Q14	Q17, Q24, Q27	Q32, Q35, Q36	Q44, Q48, Q52, Q55
Fear and the imagination	Q3, Q7, Q9, Q10	Q15, Q17, Q31	Q41	Q45, Q52
Adults who do not see	Q2, Q11, Q12, Q13	Q27, Q28, Q29, Q30	Q37, Q38, Q39, Q40, Q43	Q44, Q46, Q47, Q56
Power and its reversals	Q8	Q18, Q20, Q21, Q23, Q25	Q32, Q33, Q34, Q35	Q48, Q49, Q50, Q51
Isolation and the lack of love	Q10	Q16, Q26, Q29	Q37, Q40, Q41, Q42, Q43	Q45, Q46, Q49
The natural world and escape		Q15, Q18, Q19, Q20, Q22, Q23, Q26, Q31		Q53, Q54
House, property and belonging	Q2, Q3, Q4, Q5			
Death	Q1			Q53, Q54

Hill's methods

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

Third-person narration that moves between minds

The narrator enters Kingshaw, Hooper and the adults in turn, often within a chapter, so the reader knows what each hides from the others. Compare Hooper's calculation 2 (10%) with the adults' self-congratulation 4 (100%).

Juxtaposition of scenes

Hill cuts between a child's distress and adult comfort without comment, as when Kingshaw's hopes at night give way to the adults in the car 13 (70%).

Flat, plain sentences at moments of crisis

The most important actions get the shortest sentences 12 (95%) 12 (100%). The reader supplies the feeling the prose withholds.

Repetition and motif

The crow returns as a stuffed object 3 (55%); notes open and close the conflict 2 (25%) 17 (45%); water comforts and then kills 9 (85%) 17 (90%).

Stock phrases as characterisation

The adults speak in ready-made formulas 4 (20%) 16 (60%), which stand in for observation.

Foreshadowing

Kingshaw's dream of falling into the sea 13 (80%) and his wish to stay in the stream 9 (85%) anticipate the ending.

Capitals and written notes

Hooper's messages are written, printed and unexplained 2 (25%) 17 (45%).

Motifs and symbols

Moths and the Red Room

Dead things kept behind glass 1 (70%); the room becomes a prison 3 (70%), and Kingshaw remembers it near the end 16 (80%).

Crows

Alive in the cornfield, stuffed on the bed 3 (55%), and remembered when he goes near the attics 16 (85%). Kingshaw also imagines Mr Hooper as a crow 5 (75%).

The castle and the title

A playground rhyme made literal at Leydell Castle 12 (5%) 12 (35%); Kingshaw thinks of himself as King of the Castle when he imagines Warings without Hooper 13 (70%).

Hang Wood and water

The place of escape and competence, and finally of death 10 (100%) 17 (90%). LitCharts contrasts the stream with the swimming pool of Kingshaw's past, where a boy called Turville made him dive 3 (35%): Kingshaw remembers the pool's artificial blue when he hesitates at the stream 7 (45%), and then finds the wild water different.

School and uniform

The new school is the trap that closes 11 (35%); the uniform makes Kingshaw look like Hooper 15 (85%).

Quote bank

56 quotations in order, each checked against the text.

Chapter 1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	1 (10%)	“one of his dead old moths” Hooper’s first words in the novel reduce his dying grandfather to a specimen. Death · Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q2	1 (5%)	“he was acquiring a dynastic sense” Joseph Hooper’s wish for continuity is ironic: what passes down the line is coldness, not feeling. House · Adults who do not see
Q3	1 (65%)	“Red paint for Red Room.” A flat, childish deduction, and the first named room in the house that will be used against Kingshaw. House · Fear and the imagination

Chapter 2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q4	2 (25%)	“I DIDN'T WANT YOU TO COME HERE” Capitals and no motive: hostility is declared before the boys meet. Cruelty and the power of the bully · House
Q5	2 (45%)	“it's my window now” Ownership is the first thing the boys fight over. House · Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q6	2 (45%)	“The scrap was brief and wordless and violent.” Three adjectives and no dialogue: the fight is summarised, not dramatised. Cruelty and the power of the bully

Chapter 3

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q7	3 (20%)	“a figure, looking down at him from one of the top windows” At first the watcher is only a figure, seen through sweat and hair. Fear and the imagination · Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q8	3 (25%)	“Hooper stood in the window of his bedroom. He watched and watched.” A paragraph later the figure is named. The repeated verb makes watching Hooper’s main activity. Cruelty and the power of the bully · Power and its reversals

Q9	3 (55%)	“that it was stuffed and dead” The crow returns as a made object, so the first attack now looks observed. Fear and the imagination · Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q10	3 (55%)	“Kingshaw lay stiff, and did not scream” Silence is his defence and his isolation: he will not call for help. Fear and the imagination · Isolation and the lack of love
Q11	3 (90%)	“I never know what Kingshaw does” Hooper’s denial is aimed at the adults, and it works. Cruelty and the power of the bully · Adults who do not see

Chapter 4

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q12	4 (20%)	“there must always be a little give and take” A stock phrase from Mr Hooper that stands in for looking at what is happening. Adults who do not see
Q13	4 (100%)	“knowing nothing of the truth” The narrator states the adults’ ignorance outright. Adults who do not see
Q14	4 (85%)	“I shall come with you” Hooper turns Kingshaw’s escape into another way of following him. Cruelty and the power of the bully

Chapter 5

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q15	5 (30%)	“There was no question of it all being an adventure.” Hill refuses the boys’ adventure story. Fear and the imagination · The natural world and escape
Q16	5 (10%)	“He had almost seven pounds.” Money given because he has no father: a small, exact detail of loneliness. Isolation and the lack of love

Chapter 6

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q17	6 (25%)	“From somewhere, Hooper had been watching.” The same pattern as the cornfield: Kingshaw is never unobserved. Cruelty and the power of the bully · Fear and the imagination

Q18	6 (95%)	“knew he was leader, again, now” In the wood the lead passes to Kingshaw. Power and its reversals · The natural world and escape
Q19	6 (5%)	“Everything around him seemed innocent” The wood before the storm: innocence is how it seems to him, not what it is. The natural world and escape

Chapter 7

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q20	7 (10%)	“It's only a din” Kingshaw’s calm in the storm, set against Hooper’s terror. The natural world and escape · Power and its reversals
Q21	7 (15%)	“given him a hold over Hooper” Kingshaw’s hope, which the narrator undercuts at once. Power and its reversals
Q22	7 (45%)	“I never want to leave it, this is the best feeling in the world” The swim: the only unmixed joy in the novel, in the water that will drown him. The natural world and escape
Q23	7 (85%)	“Kingshaw felt responsible for him” His decency in the wood; it will buy him nothing. Power and its reversals · The natural world and escape

Chapter 8

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q24	8 (15%)	“It's crueller. You're a bully.” The only time the word is used to Hooper’s face, and in the wood, away from the adults. Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q25	8 (100%)	“Their roles had not been reversed, but still, something had changed” The narrator measures the change exactly, and limits it. Power and its reversals

Chapter 9

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q26	9 (85%)	“I don't want them to come, I don't want them to find us” Kingshaw would rather stay in the water than be rescued: the ending is foreshadowed. The natural world and escape · Isolation and the lack of love

Chapter 10

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q27	10 (0%)	“he pushed me in the water” Hooper’s lie cancels the night in the wood, and the adults believe it. Cruelty and the power of the bully · Adults who do not see
Q28	10 (90%)	“that is a wicked, wicked way to talk” His mother judges the words and never asks the reason. Adults who do not see
Q29	10 (65%)	“she will marry Mr Hooper” A sentence that closes off the future. Adults who do not see · Isolation and the lack of love
Q30	10 (85%)	“It is probably such a tiny thing bothering you” His mother’s offer of help shrinks the problem before she has heard it. Adults who do not see
Q31	10 (100%)	“There is the wood. Terrifying and safe.” Two opposite adjectives for the one place he can go. The natural world and escape · Fear and the imagination

Chapter 11

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q32	11 (75%)	“I can make anybody do anything to you” Hooper carries the threat forward to the new school. Cruelty and the power of the bully · Power and its reversals

Chapter 12

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q33	12 (35%)	“I'm King of the Castle!” The title rhyme, shouted by Kingshaw at the height of his power. Power and its reversals
Q34	12 (90%)	“any power he acquired would only be temporary” He knows the pattern; the novel has shown it three times. Power and its reversals
Q35	12 (95%)	“He knew that he would not.” Kingshaw’s moral choice, in five plain words. Power and its reversals · Cruelty and the power of the bully

Q36	12 (100%)	“swayed and fell” Hooper’s fall follows Kingshaw’s offer of help; the cause is fear, not a push. Cruelty and the power of the bully

Chapter 13

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q37	13 (0%)	“being ignored” What Kingshaw remembers most about the fall. Adults who do not see · Isolation and the lack of love
Q38	13 (10%)	“It would have looked like a push” He understands how the adults will see it. Adults who do not see
Q39	13 (75%)	“There is to be no blame” Mr Hooper absolves everyone, and the matter is closed. Adults who do not see
Q40	13 (100%)	“shame and gratitude and relief” The only comfort he receives in the novel is from Hooper’s father. Isolation and the lack of love · Adults who do not see

Chapter 14

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q41	14 (40%)	“he feared Hooper more than he feared anything in the world” The confession made alone, in an empty church. Fear and the imagination · Isolation and the lack of love
Q42	14 (85%)	“Kingshaw could have wept for envy of his assurance” Fielding’s ease shows what Kingshaw lacks. Isolation and the lack of love
Q43	14 (80%)	“But he couldn't actually hurt you” Fielding cannot see the danger; goodness without understanding. Adults who do not see · Isolation and the lack of love

Chapter 15

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q44	15 (65%)	“Your mother tells me lots of things about you” The adults pass Kingshaw’s secrets to Hooper. Adults who do not see · Cruelty and the power of the bully

Q45	15 (85%)	“he knew that there was no more hope for him” The uniform makes the future certain. Isolation and the lack of love · Fear and the imagination
Q46	15 (100%)	“I think that you should be very, very ashamed of yourself.” His mother’s verdict, spoken from the doorway after the model is smashed. Adults who do not see · Isolation and the lack of love

Chapter 16

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q47	16 (60%)	“such great friends” Mrs Kingshaw’s stock phrase for a friendship she does not understand. Adults who do not see
Q48	16 (40%)	“you just will. And what I say” Hooper promises that the marriage will give him power over Kingshaw. Power and its reversals · Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q49	16 (80%)	“at the unfairness of it” Tears at the end of the Red Room scene with Fielding. Isolation and the lack of love · Power and its reversals
Q50	16 (100%)	“Hooper would still know” Revenge planned in the knowledge that it changes nothing. Power and its reversals
Q51	16 (100%)	“expected to feel exultant, but there was nothing much” Revenge brings him nothing. Power and its reversals

Chapter 17

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q52	17 (45%)	“Something will happen to you, Kingshaw.” The last note answers the first and is never explained. Cruelty and the power of the bully · Fear and the imagination
Q53	17 (70%)	“This was his place” The wood claimed as his own on the last morning. The natural world and escape · Death
Q54	17 (90%)	“breathed in a long, careful breath” The careful, ordinary verb makes the act deliberate. Death · The natural world and escape

Q55	17 (95%)	“a spurt of triumph went through him” Hooper’s response to the death; the novel gives him no remorse. Cruelty and the power of the bully
Q56	17 (95%)	“everything is all right” Mrs Kingshaw’s comfort, given to the wrong boy. Adults who do not see

Past questions

Twenty past questions on the novel (Cambridge 0486, 2014–2016), arranged in chapter order. Each extract is mapped to the novel by chapter and position.

> **How to use these for the 2028 paper.** Every paper here offered a passage-based question. From 2028 Paper 1 sets two essay questions on each prose text and no passage-based question (syllabus pp. 9, 36). Use the extract questions for close-reading practice, since an essay paragraph still needs this kind of analysis of a moment, and treat the essay alternatives as the closest match to the current paper.

Essay questions most likely to recur

Across these papers the essay alternatives return to the same subjects: Fielding (four times), Mrs Kingshaw (twice), Mr Hooper (twice), sympathy for Hooper, the adults, Warings, Leydell Castle, the countryside, dead creatures, blame for the death and its inevitability. The theme arcs and character profiles are built to cover each of these.

P1 Chapter 3 3 (50–60%) 0486/13/O/N/15

Passage: from “Kingshaw woke. The room was quite silent.” to “But when he got back, the crow had gone.”

Passage-based: How effectively does Hill’s writing create a sense of terror at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: To what extent does Hill make the adults in the novel difficult to admire?

Look for. Silence and half-waking; the shape on the bed; delayed recognition; his refusal to scream; the crow gone in the morning.

P2 Chapter 3 3 (50–60%) Code not printed on supplied page

Passage: from “Kingshaw woke. The room was quite silent.” to “But when he got back, the crow had gone.”

Passage-based: In what ways does Hill vividly create tension at this moment in the novel? (Same extract as above, set on another paper.)

Alternative: How does Hill movingly portray Kingshaw’s friendship with Fielding?

Look for. As above; note how the same passage can be asked about through “tension” or “terror”.

P3 Chapter 3 3 (15–25%) 0486/13/M/J/14

Passage: from “Sweat was running down his forehead and into his eyes.” to “Hooper stood in the window of his bedroom. He watched and watched.”

Passage-based: Explore the ways in which Hill vividly conveys Kingshaw’s terror here.

Alternative: To what extent does Hill make you feel sympathy for Mrs Kingshaw? Support your ideas with details from the writing.

Look for. The bird’s physical presence; his screaming; the refusal to go to his mother; the final line naming Hooper at his bedroom window.

P4 Chapter 3 3 (15–25%) Code not printed on supplied page

Passage: from “His progress was very slow, through the cornfield” to “Hooper stood in the window of his bedroom. He watched and watched.”

Passage-based: How does Hill make this moment in the novel so frightening?

Alternative: To what extent does Hill encourage you to sympathise with Mr Hooper?

Look for. As above, with the slow approach through the corn adding suspense.

P5 Chapter 3 3 (70–80%) 0486/12/M/J/16

Passage: from “Kingshaw stood about in the hall. Hooper did not come.” to “After a moment, his footsteps went away down the hall. A door closed somewhere.”

Passage-based: How does Hill’s writing convey Kingshaw’s increasing sense of unease here?

Alternative: How does Hill make Fielding such a memorable character?

Look for. Waiting; Hooper’s questions about fear; the moth cases; the key turned in the lock.

P6 Chapter 3 3 (70–80%) Code not printed on supplied page

Passage: from “Kingshaw stiffened and moved slowly towards the first of the glass cases.” to “After a moment, his footsteps went away down the hall. A door closed somewhere.”

Passage-based: How does Hill vividly convey Hooper’s cruelty at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Hill strikingly portrays Mrs Kingshaw.

Look for. Hooper’s taunting questions; the moths; the locking; the footsteps going away.

P7 Chapter 3 3 (80–90%) 0486/11/M/J/16

Passage: from “At once, Kingshaw went to the window, averting his eyes from the moths.” to “I didn't know he was in there, I never know what Kingshaw does.”

Passage-based: How does Hill’s writing vividly convey Kingshaw’s state of mind at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Hill makes the visit to Leydell Castle so memorable and significant.

Look for. The storm outside; the moths behind him; his refusal to shout; Hooper’s denial next morning.

P8 Chapter 4 4 (65–75%) 0486/11/O/N/15

Passage: from “He had two other things to take along to the room with the dolls.” to “Kingshaw reached slowly into the back pocket of his jeans, and fetched out the key.”

Passage-based: What impressions of the two boys does Hill’s writing create for you at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: How far does Hill show that Charles Kingshaw’s sense of duty contributes to his death?

Look for. Kingshaw’s careful preparations; Hooper’s discovery; the handing over of the key.

P9 Chapter 4 4 (20–25%) 0486/13/O/N/14

Passage: from “On the train from London, Joseph Hooper said” to “He felt exonerated.”

Passage-based: What do you think Hill reveals about the father and son – and their relationship – at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: Explore two moments in the novel where you think Hill’s portrayal of the English countryside is particularly powerful.

Look for. Joseph’s questions and Edmund’s evasions; the comic; his self-justification ending in “exonerated”.

P10 Chapter 5 5 (85–100%) 0486/13/M/J/16

Passage: from “So he was proud of himself, now, that he had reached the edge of Hang Wood” to “When he opened them, he was inside Hang Wood.”

Passage-based: How does Hill’s writing vividly convey Kingshaw’s thoughts and feelings at this point in the novel?

Alternative: Who does Hill’s writing suggest is most to blame for Kingshaw’s death at the end of the novel?

Look for. Pride in his planning; fear at the edge of the wood; the threshold crossed with eyes closed.

P11 Chapter 6 6 (85–100%) 0486/11/M/J/15

Passage: from “Hooper was standing a couple of yards away, scraping at the leaf mould with his toe.” to “From somewhere, far away, came the first rumble of thunder.”

Passage-based: How does Hill strikingly convey the emotions of the two boys at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Hill shows how the relationship between Mr Hooper and Mrs Kingshaw makes matters worse for Charles Kingshaw.

Look for. Tracking the deer; Hooper’s scorn turning to fear; the thunder at the end.

P12 Chapter 7 7 (20–25%) 0486/12/M/J/15

Passage: from “Kingshaw ignored him. He picked up the rabbit cautiously.” to “So you'd better watch out, hadn't you? But it's all guff, really.”

Passage-based: How does Hill’s writing make this moment in the novel revealing and significant?

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Hill memorably presents Kingshaw’s relationship with Fielding.

Look for. The dead rabbit; Hooper’s talk of souls and ghosts; Kingshaw silenced but still anxious.

P13 Chapter 8 8 (90–100%) 0486/12/M/J/14

Passage: from “Kingshaw leaped up, maddened by Hooper's voice, going on and on.” to “He tried not to think what would happen if nobody did come for them.”

Passage-based: In what ways do you think Hill makes this such a dramatic moment in the novel?

Alternative: How does Hill make Hooper such a terrifying figure in the novel?

Look for. Kingshaw’s rage at Hooper’s voice; roles not reversed but something changed; fear that no one will come.

P14 Chapter 9 9 (35–100%) 0486/12/O/N/14

Passage: from “I'm going to swim,' he said later.” to “his view of the tree-tops and the sunlight was blocked, by a man's head.”

Passage-based: How does Hill at this moment in the novel powerfully convey Kingshaw’s feeling that he has escaped, but also suggest that he has not?

Alternative: What does Hill make you feel about Mr Hooper’s attitudes towards his son and towards Kingshaw?

Look for. Lying in the water; peace and freedom; the shout; the man’s head blocking the sky.

P15 Chapter 12 12 (20–35%) 0486/12/O/N/15

Passage: from “What are you going to do?' Kingshaw looked down at him coldly.” to “If he could jump it, he would be out on the parapet, leading to the tower.”

Passage-based: What does Hill’s writing make you feel at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: How does Hill’s writing powerfully show that Kingshaw is an easy target for Hooper’s tormenting?

Look for. Kingshaw’s cold power on the wall; Hooper’s fear; the height.

P16 Chapter 14 14 (75–85%) Code not printed on supplied page

Passage: from “Fielding said, 'Why don't you run away then?'” to “nothing will ever happen to Fielding, not ever, just because he doesn't care, because he is like this.”

Passage-based: How does Hill vividly portray Fielding at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: Explore the ways in which Hill makes Warings such a memorable setting in the novel.

Look for. Fielding’s easy questions; Kingshaw’s confession; envy of his assurance.

P17 Chapter 14 14 (35–45%) 0486/11/M/J/14

Passage: from “Kingshaw stood on the gate for a long time, looking up the ploughed field ahead.” to “You're not supposed to go inside those railings.”

Passage-based: Explore the ways in which Hill makes Kingshaw’s situation at this moment in the novel seem so distressing.

Alternative: How do you think Warings contributes to the power of the novel?

Look for. Loneliness while Hooper is in hospital; the empty church and the prayer; Fielding’s sudden voice at the end.

P18 Chapter 14 14 (70–75%) 0486/11/O/N/14

Passage: from “Kingshaw's eyes pricked, he thought of each bird” to “Fielding took the hamster and dumped it back inside the blue cage.”

Passage-based: How do you think Hill makes this moment in the novel so moving?

Alternative: In what ways does Hill make you feel that Kingshaw’s death is inevitable?

Look for. The birds killed on the farm; Fielding’s matter-of-factness; the hamster held in Kingshaw’s hand.

P19 Chapter 15 15 (80–95%) 0486/13/M/J/15

Passage: from “Mr Hooper said, 'This is the Strand, this is Trafalgar Square” to “He did not look at her.”

Passage-based: How does Hill vividly convey the unfairness which Charles Kingshaw experiences at this point in the novel?

Alternative: Does Hill’s writing make it possible for you to feel any sympathy for Hooper?

Look for. London and the uniform; the model given away; Mr Hooper’s blow; his mother’s words.

P20 Chapter 16 16 (70–80%) 0486/12/F/M/15

Passage: from “Do you want to see something else now?” to “His eyes suddenly pricked with tears, at the unfairness of it. WHY?”

Passage-based: How does Hill’s writing make the changing relationship between the boys so compelling at this moment in the novel?

Alternative: Explore some of the ways in which Hill makes dead creatures significant in I’m the King of the Castle. (Do not use the extract printed in Question 17 in answering this question.)

Look for. Hooper drawing Fielding in; Kingshaw left outside; tears and “WHY?” at the unfairness.

Self-test

11 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **What does Hooper drop from his window on the first day?**
   A key / A moth / A note wrapped round a lump of plasticine / A stuffed crow
2. **What is kept in the Red Room?**
   A model galleon / Army Lists / Cases of moths and butterflies collected by Hooper's grandfather / Stuffed crows
3. **What does Kingshaw find on his bed after the cornfield?**
   A dead rabbit / A moth case / A note / A stuffed crow
4. **How much money does Kingshaw take when he runs away?**
   Almost seven pounds / Nothing / Ten shillings / Twenty pounds
5. **What frightens Hooper in Hang Wood?**
   The deer / The fire / The stream / The thunderstorm
6. **What does Hooper tell the adults when they are found?**
   That Kingshaw pushed him into the water / That Kingshaw saved him / That he ran away alone / That they were kidnapped
7. **What is the name of the new school?**
   Drummonds / Leydell / St Vincent's / Warings
8. **Where does Hooper fall?**
   Down the stairs / From the roof of Warings / From the wall of Leydell Castle / Into the stream
9. **What does Fielding show Kingshaw?**
   A calf being born / A deer / A fox's earth / His school
10. **What does the last note say will happen?**
    That Hooper will tell / That something will happen to Kingshaw / That the wedding is off / That they will be friends
11. **Who finds Kingshaw's body?**
    Fielding / Hooper / Mr Hooper / Mrs Kingshaw

Answers

1. A note wrapped round a lump of plasticine 2 (20%)
2. Cases of moths and butterflies collected by Hooper's grandfather 1 (70%)
3. A stuffed crow 3 (55%)
4. Almost seven pounds 5 (10%)
5. The thunderstorm 7 (10%)
6. That Kingshaw pushed him into the water 10 (0%)
7. Drummonds 11 (35%)
8. From the wall of Leydell Castle 12 (5%)
9. A calf being born 14 (60%)
10. That something will happen to Kingshaw 17 (45%)

11. Hooper 17 (90%)

Sources

- Susan Hill, *I'm the King of the Castle*, with the author's Afterword.
- Cambridge International, *Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475: Syllabus for 2028, 2029 and 2030*; and the 0475 syllabus for 2027.
- The iSWIM primer, Reading Journal, Deeper Ideas, Quote and Event Bank: Key Insights, and Power, Control and Prestige notes.
- Past questions on the novel, Cambridge 0486 (2014–2016).
- LitCharts, *I'm the King of the Castle* (LitCharts LLC, 2020).